

Your Site Got a Big Upgrade

A report for Cyrus about nanogames.app · August 4, 2026

Hi Cyrus. I worked on your website today. Here's what changed, what I decided, and **why**. There's a quiz at the end.

1. You Have 8 Games Now

6 → 8

Anthill and Nano Slime are live. I checked – both work.

2. The Mystery of the Twin Files

There were **two copies** of Nano Slime on the computer. They looked the same. I compared them line by line, and the game part was identical – same monsters, same pumpkins, same slime forms.

But one had a hidden problem. It could not **save**.

Think of two backpacks

They look the same. You put your homework in one and carry it to school – it's still there. You put your homework in the other, and by the time you get to school it's gone, because that backpack has a hole in the bottom.

Play the broken Nano Slime and close the tab, and **everything you earned disappears**. All your goo. Your costumes. Your best form.

The dangerous part: the broken one **looks completely normal**. No error message. No warning. It just quietly forgets. I put the **good copy** on your site, so progress now sticks.

I also deleted an old leftover copy of Aqua Survivor that your site wasn't using. Nothing was lost – your project uses **Git**, which remembers every version of every file forever, like a time machine.

New word: a "bug" – a mistake in code that makes a program do the wrong thing. The worst bugs are the quiet ones that don't look like mistakes at all.

3. The Big One: Leaderboards 🏆

A **leaderboard** is the list of top scores. Before today, only **3** of your games had one: Aqua Survivor, Elemental Trials, and Haunted Mansion.

Here's the problem. The instructions for building that leaderboard were written out **three separate times** – about 390 lines of code, copied into each game.

Imagine writing your game rules in three notebooks

Then you find a mistake. Now you have to fix it in **all three**. Forget one, and that notebook has different rules than the others – and nobody knows which is right.

I rewrote it so there's **one single copy** that all the games share. One rulebook everybody reads from.

1,551 lines → 40 lines

Same features. Way less code.

Now a fix in one place reaches every game at once. And giving a brand new game a leaderboard takes about **6 lines** instead of 390.

New word: "don't repeat yourself" – a rule real programmers follow. If you're copying and pasting the same code over and over, write it once and share it instead.

4. Decisions I Made (And Why) 🤔

Sprite Forge gets NO leaderboard

Sprite Forge is a **drawing tool**, not a game. No way to win, no way to lose, so no score. A board with nothing to rank would just confuse people. **7 games have leaderboards. Sprite Forge doesn't.**

Anthill is ranked by TIER, not FOOD

This is the one I really want you to get.

Anthill is an **idle game** – your ants keep collecting food even while the game is closed, up to 8 hours' worth. So imagine the board ranked players by **total food**. Who wins?

Not the best player – the most patient one

A kid who plays really well for an hour might collect 5,000 food. A kid who taps once, closes the tab, goes to school, and comes back 8 hours later might have **more** – having done nothing.

The board wouldn't measure skill. It'd measure *who waited longest*.

So Anthill ranks by **colony tier** – how far you actually got. Food still shows, but only to break ties. Waiting helps a little; the top spot goes to whoever **played best**.

Every game gets its own words

Game	Ranked by	Also shows
Haunted Mansion	Score	Spiders, Room
Aqua Survivor	Time	Kills, Level
Elemental Trials	Score	Bosses, Stage
Anthill	Tier	Food, Raids
Nano Slime	Form	Goo, Pumpkins
Luffy's Quest	Score	Waves, Island
Quadratic Quest	Score	Gates, Distance

A board that says "SPIDERS" in your haunted house feels like it belongs to *that* game.

Fun thing: I got three of these **wrong** at first. I guessed what each game counted before I read the code. Turns out Luffy's Quest never counts how many enemies you beat (it counts

waves), and Quadratic Quest never counts crystals (they just add to your score). So I fixed the labels to match what your games *actually* track. **Reading beats guessing.**

5. Your Old Scores Are Safe

When you rewrite a big chunk of a site, the scary question is: **did I break anything?** So I checked the real live site afterward.

Game	Top score still saved
Elemental Trials	CYRUS – 5,250
Haunted Mansion	Deke – 3,150
Aqua Survivor	Deke – 77

Your 5,250 survived. 🎉 That check is called **testing** – making sure your change worked instead of just hoping. Hoping is not a plan.

6. The Games Can Talk Now

For most of today those four boards were **empty**. The scoreboard was built and hanging on the wall, but the games didn't **shout out the score** when you finished. The board was listening. Nobody was talking.

Now they talk. Three were easy – Luffy's Quest and Quadratic Quest already had a clear "game over" moment, and Nano Slime has the moment your slime dies. Each one now calls out its score, and the board hears it.

Anthill was the interesting one. It has no ending at all – the colony just keeps growing. So there's no moment to shout at.

So we flipped it around

Every other game: the **game tells** the scoreboard when you finish.

Anthill: the **scoreboard asks** the game. When you press SUBMIT, the board taps the game on the shoulder and says "how's the colony doing?" – and the game answers.

Same scoreboard. Opposite direction. When a problem doesn't fit, sometimes you turn it around instead of forcing it.

One more detail: Nano Slime's **sandbox** is for testing builds, so scores from it do *not* go to the board. That'd be like practicing with cheat codes on and then putting it on the record.

I checked that the code is valid and that real scores are accepted. But **nobody has actually played them yet** – that part is your job.

7. One Last Thing: Cheating 🐱

Your games run in the web browser, so someone who knows how could fake a score. We can't fully stop that. But I set a **maximum** for every game – if Anthill's highest tier is 50, the site refuses anything above 50. A cheater can't post 999,999,999. The board stays believable.

What To Do Next

1. Play Anthill and Nano Slime on the real site.
2. Check that Nano Slime **saves** – play, close the tab, come back.
3. **Play each new game to the end** and check the score screen pops up. This hasn't been tested by a real player yet – you're the first.
4. In Anthill, press SUBMIT and make sure your tier, food, and raids look right.
5. Decide what Quadratic Quest should rank on. It's Score now, but **Gates solved** is the math part. Your call.

Quiz Time

Try it without looking back. Answers on the last page.

1. How many games are on nanogames.app now?

- a) 5
- b) 6
- c) 8
- d) 12

2. What was wrong with the bad copy of Nano Slime?

- a) The monsters were missing
- b) It couldn't save your progress
- c) It was too slow
- d) The colors were wrong

3. True or false: the broken copy showed an error message so you'd know something was wrong.

TRUE / FALSE

4. Before the rewrite, the leaderboard code was copied how many times?

- a) Once
- b) Two times
- c) Three times
- d) Eight times

5. Why is copying the same code over and over a bad idea?

6. Which game does NOT get a leaderboard, and why?

7. Why would ranking Anthill by total **food** be unfair?

8. Anthill never ends, so it can't shout out a score when you finish. What did we do instead?

- a) Gave it a fake ending
- b) The scoreboard asks the game for the score when you press SUBMIT
- c) Left Anthill off the board
- d) Made the game shorter

9. Why did we set a *maximum* score for each game?

- a) To make the games harder
- b) To save space
- c) So a cheater can't post a giant fake number
- d) Because the database is small

10. Which game has no ending at all, which makes submitting a score tricky?

- a) Haunted Mansion
- b) Anthill
- c) Luffy's Quest
- d) Sprite Forge

BONUS. Your top score on Elemental Trials survived the rewrite. What was it?

Answers

No peeking until you've finished!

1. **c) 8** – up from 6.
2. **b) It couldn't save your progress.** The game itself was identical.
3. **FALSE.** That's what made it dangerous – it looked normal and quietly forgot everything.
4. **c) Three times** – in Aqua Survivor, Elemental Trials, and Haunted Mansion.
5. Because a mistake has to be fixed in **every copy**. Miss one and it behaves differently from the others.
6. **Sprite Forge** – it's a drawing tool. No way to win or lose, so no score to rank.
7. Because ants collect food while the game is **closed**. The winner would be whoever left it alone longest, not whoever played best.
8. **b) The scoreboard asks the game** when you press SUBMIT. Every other game tells the board; Anthill gets asked. Same board, opposite direction.
9. **c) So a cheater can't post a giant fake number.**
10. **b) Anthill** – it's an idle game, so it never stops.
11. **5,250** 🎉

How did you do?

9-11 right: You understand your own codebase better than most grown-ups understand theirs.

6-8 right: Solid. Reread the leaderboard section.

5 or fewer: Read it again slower. This is real engineering – it's genuinely tricky.